

“My Body Feels Like it’s Coming Off: On Cis People Touching In *Love Is Blind*”

In a reality TV show called *Love is Blind*, an American couple, Paul and Micah, visit a cenote in Mexico. Micah notices a school of fish, which scares her,

Micah: Is that a shark?

Paul: What do you mean shark? Oh, they're catfish. They look like baby, like, tiny nurse sharks.

Micah: Okay, this is kind of scaring me. It's my worst nightmare if one touches me.

Paul: These little catfish?

Micah: Yeah.

Paul: You're not their mommy. (*Love is Blind*, Season 4, Episode 5, “Paradise Lost”)

Paul and Micah have agreed to get married, but they only just met in person a day or so ago. Before that, they had been talking through a wall, getting to know each other and falling in love without ever having seen each other. Once they agree to marry, the rules of the show go, they are allowed to meet in person—a meeting that typically marks when the relationship starts to fall apart. For Paul and Micah, theirs will last all the way until the wedding day, when Paul rejects Micah on the altar. The reason, he later explains, is because he “struggled with... envisioning Micah as, like, you know, a mother” (Season 4, Episode 12, “Eternal Bliss?”).

The point of going on the show, as one participant puts it, “to be loved for who I am on the inside,” (Season 2, Episode 3, “Love in Paradise”). However, the show’s main gambit, that “love is blind,” suggests a transgressive premise that undergirds an ultimately heteronormative teleology. Despite the promise of marriage and happily-ever-after,

something non-normative is happening here. And that something has to do with the body, and what happens to the body when it falls in love from behind a wall.

This paper explores, in the words of Micah above, how “touch” can be, for cis people, their “worst nightmare.” I take readings of normativity from Trans Studies and apply them to an analysis of cisgendered subjects from the show. I examine what this situation, where visual access to the beloved is denied, does to the self-perception of the body of the participants. I find that this “blind” dating experiment places participants in a state where their own bodily coherence fractures, which has consequences on their romantic trajectory and aspirations. While firmly anchored to their cisgendered identities, the participants undergo a split in the physical body, which begins to accrue investments to integrity and wholeness that inevitably go unfulfilled once they are united with their beloveds. Through this process, I argue, they enter a temporary version of what Jay Prosser calls the “transsexual trajectory” (6). For Prosser, this trajectory “bring[s] into view the materiality of the body,” and the external manifestation of its parts, such as the internal “body image” (12). I argue that this dating experiment has a similar effect on these cisgendered subjects who, sequestered from the sight of the other, are placed on a “route to identity and bodily integrity,” which they are unlikely to achieve (6).

To surface this trajectory in *LiB*, I apply a reading method that synthesizes details of the dating experience into common patterns. Using the transcripts from the show, I created a text generator that mimics the speech of the participants.¹ I chose this method because it abstracts from specific examples—the transcripts of the show—to synthesize common and shared investments in language. It allows me to study language in a “normalized” form, which I explain in more detail below.

¹ The code and datasets used to train my models are published under an open license on github.com/ANONYMIZED/love_blind.

I also chose this method in attempt to push against dominant uses of machine learning technology. Amid what Emily Bender and Alex Hanna call “AI hype,” it is important to explore applications of machine learning that are not environmentally devastating or extractive as the commercial-level models developed by tech monopolies. By contrast, the model for this project is a fraction of the size of the models that run applications like ChatGPT, meaning the hardware, electricity, and data used for developing and running the model are miniscule in comparison, and can be carried out on a single laptop.²

The specifics of the prediction process, as I explain below, are central to my theorizing about normativity and how to study it. The current emphasis on using machine learning for to produce new content, while serving extractive and monetizing purposes, misses the fact that these tools are primarily *self-reflexive*. As Wendy Chun points out, predictive tools might be used to discover and study existing patterns in data, rather than simply generate more content for the sake of productivity. She compares common machine learning applications, like those that drive ChatGPT, with climate change models, asking, “How can we treat machine learning systems and their predictions like those for global climate change? These models offer us the most probable future given past and current actions, not so that we will accept their predictions are inevitable, but rather so we will use them to help change the future” (26). Rather than using machine learning as a means to an end (generating text for the sake of creating content), machine learning can be used to better understand the data that we already have.

In working with the *LiB* transcripts, this project takes Chun's point to an application

²For example, this project uses GPT-2, which is initially trained off only 8 million webpages and released under an open license. Compare that with the most recent version of GPT, GPT-5, which is trained on something like the entire internet and is over 600 billion parameters in size, a number that cannot be confirmed due to its closed and proprietary status. While the training process for my model took less than an hour, and was all done on my single Mac laptop, commercial-level models require multiple rounds and massive computer “clusters,” containing hundreds to thousands of GPUs, and months of training.

that is specific to studying normativity. Prediction, in addition to being a descriptive mechanism, is also a normalizing one. Within the prediction process itself, there are protocols that regularize language expression, that find and amplify frequent patterns of word usage. From repeated phrasings and frequent words in the show transcripts, this method distils or “normalizes” the dominant tendencies and perspectives embedded in the language. Prediction is, in this sense, an apt tool for studying shared and normative investments in language—a crucial area of interest for Trans Studies, as Andrea Long Chu puts it: “Trans Studies requires that we understand—as we never have before—what it means to be attached to a norm, by desire, by habit, by survival” (“After Trans Studies” 108).

The Method

I will demonstrate this normalizing process with an example. I prompted the model, which I trained on the transcripts on the show, with the phrase “Love is.” It then generated the following outputs:

Love is really important to me.

Love is what I need in my life.

Love is everything that I've been looking for. (Appendix 1)

None of these examples actually appear in the transcripts of the show. In fact, the only examples of sentences that begin with “Love is” are, perhaps predictably, followed by the word “blind.” The second half of the sentences in these outputs, then, are not filled by verbatim extracts of text of the show: rather, they are filled in by phrases that appear in similar contexts or are closely associated with the word “Love” in the transcripts. Instead of reproducing verbatim expressions, the model generates approximations of expressions within the transcripts.

But how does the model know which words are approximations? In the model's

internal representation, each word is represented a long list of numbers, or probabilities.

These long list of probabilities function effectively like the word's definition. Within the long list of probabilities, each individual probability score represents that word's relationship to *another word* in the dataset. For the model, that word is represented and defined by a chain of these probability scores, which correlate that word's relationship to a chain of other words in the dataset. So, in a kind of literalization of the poststructuralist floating signifier, a single word is defined as, not what it means in itself, but how it relates to (and differs from) every single other word. Using these lists of probabilities, a model will then know which words are most likely to appear together.

In order to compile these probability scores, however, the model must first be trained on a dataset, such as the transcripts of the show. First, the model takes a sample sentence from the transcript, like "Love is blind," and it blocks out the second half of the sentence, so that only "Love is" remains. It tries to guess which word or phrase should go in that second half. Because the model has no idea what the words mean, the guess will be wrong. Afterward, it checks its prediction against the actual sentence. Because the guess is inevitably wrong, there will always be a difference between the prediction and the actual result. And this is when the model starts to compile its list of probabilities, keeping track of which words tend to appear with each other in context. The more that certain words appear together or in similar contexts, the higher the probability score between those two words. Each time that the model makes a subsequent guess, it updates its internal representation of the word to reflect its probable association (or lack of association) to certain words.

The model will make guess after guess, trying out many words, perhaps every word in the dataset, until it is sure of those that are most likely to appear together. With each guess, the model makes *very slight* adjustments to its own representation of word meaning (this constant iteration, and the computer processing required to do it, is why language models take

lots of time, energy, and computer hardware to train). By the end, the list of probabilities will reflect a kind of average of that word's association to other words.

Coming back to the prompt, “Love is,” the model will ascertain possible completions for this phrase, given other words that are associated with “Love” in the dataset. One actual completion it gives, “really important to me,” reflects an implicit association between “Love” and “really important.” In the actual transcript of the show, this phrase “really important” appears in the following excerpt: “I have a great career, I have a condo, and the one thing I've been missing is finding someone to share all that with. And that's a really important reason why I'm here” (Season 2, Episode 1, “The Pods Are Open!”). This means that in the model's internal representation, the phrases “great career,” “condo,” and “someone to share it with” have already been associated—either directly or through a relation to another word—with that of “love.” Unsurprisingly, given the heteronormative nature of the dataset, these are all words that have to do with long-term commitment. So the model will input a phrase that also appears in this context, such as “really important,” and use that phrase to complete the prompt, “love is.”

This completion explains why the model does *not* generate “Love is blind,” despite the frequent repetition of that phrase in the transcript. The model does not spew verbatim extracts of the show; rather, it approximates word meaning by examining word contexts and averaging probabilities of association. The model determines then, that “Love” is associated with words having to do with heteronormative milestones and desires. I read this associative mechanism, this approximation of word meaning, as a kind of *normalization* of language. The model generates language by approximating what is most likely, most plausible, based on its training data. As such, it is ideal for studying shared perceptions and attachments by the characters on the show.

The Outputs

The show contains two stages, the pre-engagement stage, where participants date each other from separate “pods” where they can hear but not see the other, and the engagement stage, where participants finally meet and proceed to live together in preparation for the wedding. In partitioning the romantic experiment into pre-engagement and engagement segments, the show poses the presence and role of the body as the variable that ultimately determines the viability of long-term commitment. In other words, it sets up an examination of how the body may affect normative trajectories and desires.

To explore the differences between these periods of the show, I trained two separate models on each of these periods: the first model is trained on the transcripts from the pods episodes, and I call it the “pods model”; the second model is trained on the episodes following the pods, and I call it the “postpods model.”³

Then, I prompted both models with input phrases about the body and touch to see how each of them would respond individually to the prompts. When prompted with phrases like “When I touch you,” and “Physical touch is,” and “Physically,” the pods model generates the following outputs:

When I touch you, I feel it.

When I touch you, I feel your energy, and it is, like, I'm just so happy.

When I touch you, I can feel your soul, your heart, and your soul aligning so well.

When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you.

Physical touch is important to me.

Physical touch is the most important thing.

Physical touch is so sexy.

³ The models for this project are published under an open license on huggingface.co/ANONYMIZED

Physical touch is like a glove.

Physically, we are so happy. (Appendix 1)

Repetitions in outputs like, “When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you,” are expected behavior in text generation models, especially those that are small and relatively underdeveloped, like this one. Because the model generates what is most likely, sometimes, it will get stuck in loops, repeating the same phrase over and over again. This quirk reinforces the predictive nature of the model, which will generate what is most plausible.⁴

The rest of the results reflect what is most plausible given the information from the training data, the transcripts. Considering that they are based on a period of the show when no actual touching occurs between the couples, it makes sense that the model would associate touch to non-tangible aspects like “soul” and “energy.” It also makes sense that touch, being foreclosed from the participants during this stage of the experiment, is elevated as something highly desired, to an “important,” “most important,” and even “sexy” quality. Finally, the last two examples, “like a glove” and “we are so happy,” suggest an association between touch and compatibility, in the sense that the couples “fit” together, so to speak.

The outputs with those from the postpods model, however, put touch in very different contexts:

When I touch you, I feel like I'm in my head.

When I touch you, you just feel like it's so weird.

When I touch you, it feels like a jab.

When I touch you, like, I feel like I'm literally in my head.

⁴While models are good at prediction, they are not at all good at being creative, at innovating. A model can only generate what it has already seen before. Even a phenomenon like “hallucination,” that a model spews text that has no bearing in reality, is based on the tendency of models to repeat what they’ve already seen. They hallucinate not because they are creative or random, but because they are designed from statistical processes to produce what is most plausible rather than most accurate.

When I touch you, it feels like something I'm about to get up and walk away.

When I touch you, I feel like it's like I've just, like, left the room.

When I touch you, the thing that's scary is, like, it's a physical thing.

When I touch you, you're like "I'm blinking." (Appendix 2)

Unlike the pods model, these outputs present touch as a *not* pleasant experience. Touch is "so weird," "like a jab," suggesting a strange and even disruptive aspect to touch. Furthermore, touch is associated with physicality, which is "scary," echoing Micah's fear of the catfish from the opening scene, "It's my worst nightmare if one touches me" (Season 4, Episode 5, "Paradise Lost"). At the same time, touch signals location and movement: "in my head," "walk away," and "left the room." While in the pods, touch drew the characters together, evoking non-tangible phenomena like the soul and energy, here it seems that touch repels the characters from each other.

A mistake by the text generator reveals something about touch's relationship to the other senses. The phrase that says, "I'm blinking," is actually taken directly from the show, and is an example of an undesired but not uncommon blip in the prediction process. In machine learning, this blip is referred to as "overfitting," when a verbatim section of text from the training data, in this case, the show transcripts, is generated in the output.

"Overfitting" means that the model is *too* accurate: that it has slipped from making predictions that are plausible to repeating exactly the data it has been trained on. A model overfitting in its outputs is generally a sign that there isn't enough training data or enough variation in the training data, meaning that the model has less examples from which to approximate and generalize. So, it resorts to simply reproducing direct examples from its training.

For my purposes, however, overfitting is not only a blip, it also points to a specific scene in the show, which highlights a tension between the sensory modes of touch and sight.

The original reference to “blinking” appears in the first meeting between a newly engaged couple, Zach and Irina:

Zach: Do I look like what you thought I'd look like?

Irina: I had no guesses of what you looked like.

Zach: Oh!

Irina: You have, like, the blankest stare in your eyes.

Zach: Really?

Irina: I'm just kind of taking it all in.

Zach: Me too.

Irina: You look like a fictional character. You look like something out of a cartoon.

Zach: I know.

Irina: You have to blink!

Zach: I am blinking.

Irina: You don't blink. You look like this.

Zach: I am blinking. I will try not to be too intense. (Season 4, Episode 4, “Playing with Fire”)

When Zach and Irina meet, it is clear that both are reacting to the reality of each other's physical form in their own ways, with Irina, in particular, asking Zach to adjust his behavior, “to blink!” Blinking is, of course, a way of stopping the entry of visual data, of occluding it from perception. For Irina, the request for Zach to blink might indicate her own sense of overwhelm at his physical form, at his sudden incorporation before her eyes. Perhaps, the visual reality of him proves too much. Projecting her own feelings of overstimulation, she asks him to blink.

In the story of Zach and Irina, it is clear that the catalyst for their breakup is a lack of

physical attraction on the part of Irina. Later in the same episode, Irina explains her feelings to Micah, who is coupled with Paul.

Irina: And so, Zack. I feel like is my type on paper. Has, like, brown hair, brown eyes, like, chiseled face. Like, I really like dark features. And the moment I saw Zack, it was like, “I don't know who this man is.” And I was like, “Maybe it's just scary, and it was a lot.” Like, hopefully it's gonna grow, but I've noticed every time he does, like, touch me, I get, like, major ick. When he puts his arm around me at night, I literally was like— like, my heart stopped. And I literally go... But not, like, in an excited way.

Micah: I wanna, like, relate to you in a way, but it's always, like, so different.

Irina: How was it with you and Paul?

Micah: The thing with me and Paul is, like, we both, like, had such an immediate understanding as best friends.

Irina: Yeah, Paul's gorgeous. (Season 4, Episode 4, “Playing With Fire”)

Zach supposedly has physical aspects which Irina finds attractive, “brown eyes, chiseled face,” but something about him nonetheless repulses her. At his touch, she recoils, “get[ting]... major ick.” While she claims her lack of attraction to Zach is not determined by his appearance, Irina simultaneously elevates the importance of visual appearance with the phrase, “Yeah, Paul's gorgeous.” Which begs the question: if Irina finds both Zach and Paul visually attractive, then, what repulses her about Zach?

The answer could be a number of things, which Irina may or may not have revealed in the course of the show. But the point is not the specific reason. Rather, it's that the model made a connection between touch and “blinking.” This connection leads to a scene where the visual sense overwhelms and may even occlude the other senses, such as touch, which is a result of the experience of the characters in the pods. It suggests that there is something about

the foreclosure of the visual sense in the pods which Irina, and perhaps other characters, want to carry with them when they leave the pods, “blinking.”

Sequestered from the sight of the other within the pods, the participants experience a kind of bodily split in which their own physical senses materialize in new and surprising ways. They experience not only the physical body, the material reality of their physical body which they've always known, but also what Jay Prosser refers to as the “body image,” an internal but no less material perception of the body. According to Prosser, “body image—which we might be tempted to align with the imaginary—clearly has a material force for transsexuals” (69). For trans subjects, this “material force” often manifests in the trope of being “trapped in the wrong body” and feelings of dysphoria.

For these cisgendered subjects, I argue, this force manifests in a heightened sensation of the body, which paradoxically creates a feeling of the body's dissolution. When prompted with the phrase “My body,” the pods model generates the following completions:

My body feels like it's coming off.

My body feels heavier.

My body feels so different now.

My body feels weird.

My body makes me feel like it's real.

My body feels torn between two different people. (Appendix 1)

At the moment where visual access to the other's body is denied, there is an increased sensing of one's own physicality. The body comes into apprehension in a novel and visceral way, which makes it seem all the more strange. The body feels “weird” and “so different now” because it is not the same body as that which also had access to the visual sense. This new body is “heavier,” more “real,” weighted with its new awareness that is almost super-real. Perhaps, the reference to being “torn between two different people” is not referring to actual

people, but to a single person with two bodies in tension. As Prosser explains, the body image creates “conflict between the true body within and the false body without, between sentient body image and insentient visible body” (70). For these straight, cisgendered participants within the pods, the body may be coming into sentience in a way that is not possible when they are fully integrated, outside the pods. And this may be the first (and only) time that they experience this level of bodily sensation and awareness.

It is not a feeling that lasts long; for in the postpods model, the body appears to be re-integrated. Here, the language about the body shifts into notably more visual and positive descriptions:

My body is gorgeous.

My body is so cute.

My body is so pretty.

My body makes me feel lighter, more confident.

My body makes me feel warm.

My body makes me feel like I've missed my train. (Appendix 2)

The outputs address the body in concise and visually flattering terms: the body is “gorgeous,” “so cute,” “pretty.” Perhaps, now that the couples can see each other, the body feels “lighter” and “warm,” suggesting coherence where before there was weight and weirdness. Despite this coherence, however, there is a lingering feeling of loss: “My body makes me feel like I've missed my train.” This statement, with its slightly nostalgic undertone, suggests that even when coherence is gained, something is lost.

What is lost comes into view when the model is prompted with statements about physical touch:

Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner.

Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife.

Physical touch is a big part of what I want.

Physically, there's so much potential here.

Physically, it was the perfect opportunity. (Appendix 2)

Physical touch is described in aspirational terms: it is “everything I've wanted,” not “everything I got.” The traces of present perfect and past tense to discuss “want” is indicative: even after meeting in person, their desire remains unfulfilled. The restoration of the visual sense, the re-integration the fractured body image, then, does not offer completion or culmination.

In the outputs, touch is evoked as aspirational perhaps because, when the couples finally meet in physical forms, they remain plagued by the possibilities for physical connection that they felt in the pods. And these expectations are what, for some of them, prevents their ability to accept their partners as they are. Being restored their visual sense heals the *LiB* participants from the bodily split, but it does not save them from the aftermath of their investments. Due to their experience in the pods, the significance of touch is inflated to include other, perhaps practically unattainable, desires. Although they exited from one trajectory, they remain stuck with the desire for a kind of touch that is “everything that I've ever wanted in a partner” (Appendix 1). Considering that the characters are now reunited with their physical bodies, there is something almost cruel in this denouement, a “cruel optimism,” in Lauren Berlant's formulation, which describes the attachment that drives desire even while it wears out the desirer.

Or, more specific to their bodily predicaments, the characters experience a version of what Hil Malatino describes as “future fatigue” (20). Like cruel optimism, future fatigue generates “intense anticipatory anxiety” that “impede[s] flourishing” (Malatino 20). Unlike cruel optimism, however, future fatigue concerns trans subjects who are invested in “the promised moment of harmony between the felt and the perceived body” (Malatino 27).

Despite being cisgendered, these subjects in *LiB* experience a bodily split, during which they develop romantic feelings and attachments. And most of them, when they leave the pods, cannot fulfil these aspirations within their embodied lives.

Cis and Trans Futures

The disruption of bodily integrity has ramifications that last well beyond the pods. Recalling the case of Paul and Micah, Paul eventually rejects Micah because he didn't see her as a mother. At the end of the season, when the host of the "Reunion" episode prods him on the topic, he struggles to articulate his reasoning:

Paul: You know, she didn't feel comfortable with showing that side of her.

Host: I thought she said she did. She just talked about it from since the pods up until your wedding day.

Paul: It wasn't evident to me... That wasn't there.

Host: You wanted actions. Like, you wanted her...

Paul: I just wanted to be able to see it, I guess. Like...

Host: What would make you see that? I'm sorry. Just so I understand.

Paul: I think... It's a little bit ineffable, right? So, it's kind of an exuding, a nurturing presence. It's something that you feel. There's not really, like... tangible, kind of like, things, I don't think. (Season 4, Episode 13 "The Reunion")

Micah claims that he failed to "see" evidence of Micah's motherly nature, but when asked to explain what this evidence would look like, answers that it is "ineffable." He supposedly wants someone who can be a mother, but cannot describe what a mother looks or acts like.

There are two final points to make here: the first is that, clearly, cis people are not okay in their bodies. That being said, however, I am not interested in a critical analysis of the

body that redeems them. I am not interested in applying, as Malatino does for trans subjects, readings of “of looseness and possibility, not yet overcoded and fixed in meaning, signification, or representative economy,” to cisgender subjects (32). After all, cis-hetero significations and dynamics are already well represented and coded. What I am interested in, rather, is the study of normativity, and how alignments between cis and trans experience might further this study.

Which brings me to my final point: that I hope my method, which approximates language as a means of surfacing shared investments, pushes back against the polarization that characterizes the current discourse in the US, and specifically that about trans rights. In this paper, I deliberately isolated the body as a potential vector of connection that flows through and between gender and sexual identities. I believe that machine learning, with its tendency to amplify what is most frequent, might reveal something shared about the body, even across very different embodied experiences.

This is an attempt to expand Trans Studies by applying its interest in the body beyond the proper or conventional areas and objects. And Trans Studies offers no dearth of theorizing on the body and its desires. I close with one quote from a study by Cassius Adair that explores “t4t erotics.” Here, Adair asks, “Why can’t the erotic be a site of producing trans identity or practices?” (46). He points out that, after all, “cis people do it all the time: all erotic desires might be sites of identity formation, for anyone” (47).

Yes, cis people do it all the time. But what they tend not to do, and which Trans Studies does so well, is to question the perimeters of their own bodies, to explore how desire and attachments manifest in material ways on the body. And perhaps, as I hope this paper has shown, that Trans Studies theorizing might open up such thinking about the body, “for anyone.”

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Appendix 1: Pods Model Outputs

Prompt: "Love is"

Outputs:

"Love is really important to me."

"Love is what I need in my life."

"Love is everything that I've been looking for."

Prompt: "When I touch you"

Outputs:

"When I touch you, I feel it."

"When I touch you, I feel your energy, and it is, like, I'm just so happy."

"When I touch you, I can feel your soul, your heart, and your soul aligning so well."

"When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you."

Prompt: "Physical touch is"

Outputs:

"Physical touch is important to me."

"Physical touch is the most important thing."

"Physical touch is so sexy."

"Physical touch is like a glove."

Prompt: "Physically,"

Outputs:

"Physically, we are so happy."

Prompt: “My body”

Outputs:

“My body feels like it's coming off.”

“My body feels heavier.”

“My body feels so different now.”

“My body feels weird.”

“My body makes me feel like it's real.”

“My body feels torn between two different people.”

Appendix 2: Postpods Model Outputs

Prompt: “When I touch you”

Outputs:

“When I touch you, I feel like I'm in my head.”

“When I touch you, you just feel like it's so weird.”

“When I touch you, it feels like a jab.”

“When I touch you, like, I feel like I'm literally in my head.”

“When I touch you, it feels like something I'm about to get up and walk away.”

“When I touch you, I feel like it's like I've just, like, left the room.”

“When I touch you, the thing that's scary is, like, it's a physical thing.”

“When I touch you, you're like 'I'm blinking.’”

Prompt: “My body”

Outputs:

“My body is gorgeous.”

“My body is so cute.”

“My body is so pretty.”

“My body makes me feel lighter, more confident.”

“My body makes me feel warm.”

“My body makes me feel like I've missed my train.”

Prompt: “Physical touch”

Outputs:

“Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner.”

“Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife.”

“Physical touch is a big part of what I want.”

“Physically, there's so much potential here.”

“Physically, it was the perfect opportunity.”